

INSTITUTIONAL CONSTITUTION · V1.0

# Al-Madeenah International College for Arabic & Islamic Studies

كلية المدينة العالمية للدراسات العربية والإسلامية

The Academic & Editorial Bible

Prepared as an independent commission. Governs identity, academic doctrine, curriculum, credentials, student experience, brand and editorial voice, financial philosophy, and institutional conduct.

## Preface — how to read this document

This is the constitutional layer beneath a website. It exists so that every later decision — a page of copy, a line of curriculum, a pixel of a certificate — can be checked against something written down in a calm hour, rather than decided in the rush of shipping. Nothing downstream should exist unless it is compatible with what is written here.

It is organised in ten parts. Parts I–III establish what the institution *is* and what it will never claim to be. Parts IV–VI establish what it *teaches* and how a student moves through it. Parts VII–IX establish how it *looks, sounds, and sustains itself*. Part X is a self-administered adversarial review of everything before it — written after the first full draft, not before, so it could find real problems rather than performing the appearance of rigour.

Two documents accompany it in the same folder: a one-page **Strategic Conclusions** summary for a reader who wants the decisions without the reasoning, and a **Founder Decision Register** — the short list of matters that cannot be settled by research, professional judgement, or precedent, and must be settled by the person who carries legal and personal responsibility for the institution.

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## PART I — THE INSTITUTION

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### §1. What Al-Madeenah is

Al-Madeenah International College for Arabic & Islamic Studies is a distance-learning institution teaching Arabic language, Qur'anic recitation and memorisation, and the Islamic sciences, to students who cannot or choose not to relocate to study them.

Distance is not a channel bolted onto a campus that does not exist. Distance is the institution's form. Every decision in this document — the pacing model, the assessment design, the certificate, the pricing — is designed for a student studying from a bedroom, a break room, or a borrowed phone, in a time zone the teacher may never share. An institution that designs for a campus and then adds a login screen has built the wrong thing twice.

**Character.** African in origin. Formed in dialogue with the Madinan scholarly tradition in substance and humility, not in imagery. Islamic in the seriousness of its scholarship rather than in its decoration. International in the geography of its students. Restrained in its presentation of prestige — the opposite of loud.

## §2. Whom it serves

Primary geography: Nigeria, wider West Africa, Francophone West Africa, the United Kingdom, continental Europe, the Gulf states, and North America, in roughly that order of near-term weight — the institution's founding market first, its diaspora second, its wider international reach third. Nothing here excludes a student from elsewhere; the list states priority, not eligibility.

Constituencies: children (subject in full to Part II §9 — no enrolment of a minor until the safeguarding structure named there is operative, without exception), teenagers, adults returning to study alongside work and family, professional Arabic learners, practising and trainee teachers, converts to Islam approaching Arabic and the tradition for the first time, and families studying in parallel.

A person is never reduced to one of these labels for the life of their relationship with the institution. §22 makes this a structural rule, not a courtesy.

## §3. The standard the institution is held to

"Authoritative" is earned by five things and only five: **serious scholarship, excellent teaching, a curriculum that would survive an external examiner's questions, credentials that mean exactly what they say and no more, and consistency sustained over years rather than a single strong launch.** An institution with a beautiful website and none of these five is a beautiful website, not an authority.

The corollary is a hard rule, not a tone note: **the institution makes no claim about itself that cannot presently be evidenced.** Not "leading." Not "world-class." Not "the finest anywhere." Not a faculty count, a student count, or a founding date it cannot substantiate publicly. Where a fact is not yet true — no enrolled cohort, no regulatory recognition, no completed accreditation review — the institution says so, in the same calm voice it uses for everything else. A gap admitted in public is a correctable weakness. A gap concealed and later discovered is not.

## §4. What Al-Madeenah deliberately is not

- Not a translated mosque pamphlet with a login page bolted on.
- Not a claimant to accreditation, university status, or degree-granting authority it has not obtained. "University," "degree," "BA/MA," and "accredited" are not used until a competent regulator has said the institution may use them (§7, §37).
- Not an ijāzah-granting body until it has scholars who can responsibly grant one (§18).
- Not a fixed four-month bootcamp wearing the language of mastery. Duration is an output of pace and demonstrated competence, not the product being sold (Part III).
- Not a second, cheaper academic standard sold to students who pay less. Part VIII makes this a structural guarantee, not an aspiration.

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## PART II — GOVERNANCE, HONESTY AND SAFEGUARDING

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### §5. The honesty doctrine

Every public-facing surface — the website, the Study environment, a certificate, an email — is bound by one rule above all others: **state what is true, state plainly what is not yet true, and never let silence imply something false.** A "coming soon" label on an inert feature is honest. A feature that looks live and goes nowhere is not. A founding date, a faculty biography, a testimonial, a student count, an award, or a partnership is never invented, rounded up, or implied through careful phrasing designed to leave a false impression while remaining technically defensible. The reader's trust is the entire product; spending it once is spending it for good.

### §6. The claims policy

No comparative or superlative claim about the institution ships without a citation the reader could in principle check: no "world-class," "leading," "best," "unrivalled," "award-winning," or "#1" of any kind, in either language, anywhere in institutional copy — including internal documents that might later be copied into public ones. Self-critical language ("this is the best version we currently know how to build") is not a claim about the institution and is exempt; the test is whether the sentence asserts a ranking against competitors the institution has not measured itself against.

### §7. Regulated and sensitive terms

"University," "degree," "accredited," and "diploma" carry specific legal meaning in enough of the institution's target jurisdictions (Nigeria's NUC/NBTE framework reserves degree-granting to universities it licenses; the UK's Consumer and Markets Authority treats higher-education marketing claims as consumer-protection matters; several jurisdictions license the operation of degree-granting institutions serving their residents) that the institution adopts a conservative default rather than wait to be challenged: **none of these four words is used to describe anything the institution offers, now or as a planned future state, until written legal advice in the relevant market says otherwise.** The award ladder in §17 is built entirely from terms — *Certificate*, *Certificate of Attainment*, *Certificate of Mastery* — that carry no such regulatory risk in the jurisdictions currently identified, so the institution is never waiting on a legal opinion to open enrolment.

## §8. Governance of decisions

Two categories of decision exist. **Institutional-judgement decisions** — curriculum design, pacing model, assessment method, brand direction, information architecture — are decided by whoever holds delegated authority for that domain, using research, professional standard practice, and the doctrine in this document, and are recorded with their reasoning so a later reviewer can see why, not just what. **Founder-only decisions** — legal registration, ownership, safeguarding appointments, budget ceilings, and anything resting on a fact only the Founder holds — are never guessed at; they are listed, with the question stated precisely, in the accompanying Decision Register, and nothing that depends on one ship until it is answered.

## §9. Safeguarding — a gate, not a policy document

An institution that will teach children at a distance, sometimes one-to-one over live video, has taken on a safeguarding obligation the moment it advertises to families, not the moment its first child enrolls. This document creates a binding gate:

**No person under 18 may be enrolled until all of the following exist and are published:** a named Safeguarding Lead independent of the teaching line; a vetting standard for every adult who will have unsupervised contact with a minor, calibrated to the strictest jurisdiction the institution actually operates in; a stated policy on recording, retaining and deleting any session involving a minor; a reporting channel a student or parent can use without going through their own teacher; and a rule, stated here permanently, that **no one-to-one live session with a minor is scheduled without a second adult present, a recording, or a parent/guardian able to observe** — the institution's choice among the three is recorded in the Decision Register, not left to individual teachers to decide session by session.

Until that structure exists, the institution serves adults and teenagers 16+ with guardian consent, under a lighter but still real verification standard, and says plainly on every admissions surface that under-16 enrolment is not yet open — not that it doesn't exist, that it *isn't open yet*, which is both true and an honest signal of intent.

## §10. Data protection and residency

The institution will hold personal data on students resident in at least three distinct legal regimes — Nigeria's Data Protection Act 2023, the UK GDPR/Data Protection Act 2018, and the EU GDPR, with Gulf and North American students adding further, lighter obligations. The doctrine, at the policy level this document governs (the engineering follows in the technology-architecture phase, not here): **one processor, a published privacy notice naming the lawful basis for each category of data collected, a stated retention period for every category, and no transfer of a student's personal data outside the jurisdiction it was collected in without a recognised lawful transfer mechanism.** No student record is created — not even a placement-assessment result tied to a name — until this is operative for the jurisdiction that student is in.

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## PART III — ACADEMIC DOCTRINE

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### §11. The central doctrine: fixed standards, flexible pace

A student may move quickly or slowly. A student may never clear a bar that is lower than the bar cleared by the student who took three times as long. This is enforced by one structural choice: **progression is gated by demonstrated mastery in front of a qualified assessor, never by attendance, elapsed time, or completed activity count**. A gate that can be passed by finishing a checklist is not a gate; it is a checklist wearing a gate's name.

Four paces sit on top of one standard, not four standards:

| Pace               | Weekly commitment (indicative) | Who it suits                                         |
|--------------------|--------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Flexible</b>    | Irregular, self-paced          | Unstable schedules, caregiving, shift work           |
| <b>Regular</b>     | 4–6 hours                      | The default: study alongside a full life             |
| <b>Intensive</b>   | 10–14 hours                    | A committed learner with real spare time             |
| <b>Accelerated</b> | 20–25 hours                    | A student able to treat this as near full-time study |

The certificate a student receives states the level reached and the date. It never states the pace at which they reached it, because the pace is not the institution's business to grade — the mastery is.

### §12. Measuring volume honestly: notional learning hours, not months

"Level 100 in two months" is a defensible claim only at the Accelerated pace, and stating it without that qualifier misleads a Regular-pace student into thinking they are behind when they are not. The institution therefore defines each level in **notional learning hours (NLH)** — a calibration of the guided study and practice a representative learner needs, informed by widely published second-language-acquisition research (CEFR guided-hours estimates and comparable calibration work for Arabic as an additional language), not a claim of exact equivalence to any external framework. **A working calibration, published as such, and explicitly due for revision once the institution has its own first-cohort completion data** — because no incoming estimate survives contact with a real cohort unchanged, and pretending otherwise would itself be a claim the institution cannot yet evidence.

| Level               | Character                                               | NLH this level | Cumulative NLH |
|---------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|----------------|----------------|
| <b>Foundation</b>   | Script, sound system, core structure, everyday register | 150            | 150            |
| <b>Intermediate</b> | Connected reading, sustained conversation, core grammar | 250            | 400            |
| <b>Advanced</b>     | Classical and Qur'anic register, extended composition   | 400            | 800            |
| <b>Mastery</b>      | Independent scholarly reading and research-level Arabic | 550            | 1,350          |

At Regular pace (5 h/week) Foundation takes roughly 30 weeks; at Accelerated pace (22 h/week) it takes roughly 7 weeks — both true simultaneously, because they describe the same standard reached at different speeds. No marketing surface states a duration without stating the pace it assumes.

### §13. The academic ladder

Three teaching faculties, plus one deliberately separate professional stream:

- **Faculty of Arabic Language** — the instrument, taught to open the tradition, not as a stand-alone communicative-language course. Assessed across five modalities: reading, listening, speaking, writing, and classical-text comprehension.
- **Faculty of Qur'an** — nazrah, tajwīd, makhārij and ṣifāt, recitation, memorisation and murāja'ah. Runs on its own ladder, independent of the Arabic ladder, because a student's Qur'an progress and their general-Arabic progress are genuinely different facts and forcing them onto one scale hides both.
- **Faculty of Islamic Sciences** — 'aqīdah, fiqh (taught for one stated madhhab, as instruction rather than adjudication, with recognised differences among the schools taught respectfully and never litigated), ḥadīth, tafsīr (gated behind Advanced-level Arabic, because tafsīr taught through translation is a different, lesser subject), sīrah, and uṣūl. The institution issues no fatwā, anywhere, including through its AI tools (§18).
- **Professional & Specialist Programmes** — a distinct, non-degree-track stream: Arabic for professionals, teacher development for those who will go on to teach Arabic or Qur'an elsewhere, corporate Arabic, and seasonal intensives (Ramadan, summer). This sits outside the core ladder deliberately — treating teacher training as a fifth peer "faculty" would imply it carries the same academic weight as three years of core study, which it does not, and folding it into the core ladder would blur a distinction a prospective student is entitled to see clearly.

## §14. School-stage qualifications: two routes, stated honestly

Where the brief's language of Ibtidā'iyyah, I'dādiyyah and Thanawiyyah implies a school-leaving credential, the institution splits it into two visibly different products rather than one page that quietly means two things:

- **The Academic Route** — open now, for any age with guardian consent where required, assessed and certificated entirely by the institution against its own published standard, at any of the four paces. Makes no claim of external recognition.
- **The Certificated School Route** — aligned to a named external examining body's syllabus and timing requirements (in Nigeria, this is the National Board for Arabic and Islamic Studies), **not built or marketed until that body's actual current requirements are confirmed in writing** and the institution has decided, with the Founder, whether to seek recognition under them at all. Until then, the admissions pages state this route does not yet exist — not that it is coming, since a coming date the institution cannot back is its own kind of false claim.

## §15. Assessment

Diagnostic and placement assessment is free, untimed, resumable, retakeable without limit, and **never shown to the student as a score** — it exists to answer "where do I start, and will I be embarrassed?", and an instrument that answers that question with a mark has failed at its only job. Formative assessment (coursework, quizzes, teacher feedback) supports learning and does not gate progression. Summative gate assessment — live recitation for Qur'an work, oral and written examination for Arabic and the Islamic sciences — is where progression is actually decided, is published in advance so every student knows exactly what mastery looks like before they attempt it, and is **free and unlimited to retake**: charging for a resit creates a financial incentive for the institution to fail students, and the institution will not build that incentive into itself even implicitly. Every assessment carries a stated appeals process and moderation by a second qualified assessor for any high-stakes gate.

**Integrity at distance** rests on live, human-observed assessment for anything that confers a credential — a written quiz can be gamed; a scholar listening to a student recite cannot be as easily fooled. Where remote proctoring software is considered for lower-stakes work, it is evaluated against the same privacy doctrine as everything else (§10) before adoption, not defaulted to because it is common practice.

## §16. Live and asynchronous learning, by design

Both modes are first-class, designed together rather than one bolted onto the other: **live** classes, live Qur'an recitation correction, office hours, and oral examination give a student a real teacher's real attention; **asynchronous** recorded lessons, structured exercises, spaced revision and independent reading let a student with an unpredictable schedule, a weak connection, or a family relying on them keep moving without being locked to



a fixed weekly slot. Every live session that can reasonably be recorded is recorded and made available, so missing it once is an inconvenience, not a setback.

## §17. Credentials

| Award                                        | Attests to                                                                                                                     | Assessed by            |
|----------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------|
| Qur'an Memorisation Certificate              | A stated portion memorised <b>and retained</b> , verified by unannounced re-testing after an interval, not merely reached once | Live recitation        |
| Tajwīd Proficiency Certificate               | Command of tajwīd rules in the declared riwāyah, demonstrated in recitation                                                    | Live recitation        |
| Certificate of Arabic Attainment — Level $n$ | Mastery of a named level across all five assessed modalities                                                                   | Level gate examination |
| Certificate of Completion                    | Attendance and completion of a defined programme, explicitly carrying no mastery claim                                         | Attendance record      |

Every certificate states on its face what it is *not* — specifically, that it is not an ijāzah and confers no chain of transmission — because the single sentence protects the student who might otherwise over-represent it, the institution's own integrity, and the tradition of transmission it does not claim to extend.

**No credential's first issue, and no verification lookup, is ever a paid product.** Fees may attach only to a replacement copy, expedited physical production, or postage — never to a student receiving proof of their own completed work for the first time. A public verification register, keyed by credential ID, returns whether a credential is genuine, what it attests to, and whether it has been revoked — nothing more — free, to anyone, without an account, permanently. This is a public utility, not a fourth portal.

## §18. Ijāzah — deferred by design, not by accident

The institution does not currently grant ijāzah in Qur'anic recitation and says so in exactly those words wherever certification is discussed. An ijāzah is a claim about an unbroken chain of transmission; granting one without a muqri' who genuinely holds that chain in the declared riwāyah is not a marketing shortcut, it is a corruption of the thing the tradition exists to protect, and the most damaging discoverable fact the institution could ever have attached to its name. The institution will move to issuing ijāzah, through named teachers holding a verified chain, with every recitation recorded in a durable register, only once such teachers are genuinely on faculty — and will refer students seeking one to named partner institutions in the meantime.

## §19. AI, used narrowly and disclosed plainly

AI tools may assist a student with Arabic mechanics — grammar drills, vocabulary practice, conversational rehearsal, revision scheduling — always visibly labelled as AI, never presented as a teacher or a scholar. AI tools **do not** generate, complete, paraphrase, or "correct" Qur'anic text, ḥadīth wording, tafsīr, or fiqh rulings, and do not issue a fatwā under any framing. Where a student asks an AI tool a question that belongs to a qualified human — "is this permissible," "what does this verse mean" — the tool declines and routes the question to a named member of faculty. This is an architectural constraint on what the tool is built to do, not a disclaimer appended to what it already does.

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# PART IV — CURRICULUM AND SIGNATURE METHODOLOGY

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## §20. Arabic Language curriculum, in outline

Reading (script through connected classical prose), writing (dictation through independent composition), listening, speaking and structured conversation, naḥw and ṣarf taught as tools for reading real text rather than as an end in themselves, balāghah at the advanced level, and a dedicated Qur'anic-Arabic strand that treats scriptural register as its own skill rather than an afterthought of general Arabic. Subjects are added because a student needs them to read, understand, and eventually teach the language — not to lengthen a prospectus.

## §21. Qur'an curriculum, in outline

Nazrah before ḥifẓ; makhārij and ṣifāt taught explicitly rather than absorbed by imitation alone; tajwīd integrated into recitation from the first lesson, not bolted on after memorisation; systematic, scheduled murāja'ah treated as a compulsory stage rather than the student's private responsibility, because unscheduled revision is the single most common cause of ḥifẓ quietly eroding; and retention — not pages reached — as the number the institution actually reports.

## §22. Islamic Sciences curriculum, in outline

ʿaqīdah, fiqh (from named texts, for one stated madhhab, taught as instruction with recognised differences among the schools presented respectfully), ḥadīth, sīrah, uṣūl, and a course on contemporary application that

treats the classical texts as living guidance rather than a museum piece — without ever functioning as a fatwā service.

## §23. The Itqān Cycle — the institution's signature teaching methodology

A named, memorable four-stage cycle governs how every unit of Arabic and Qur'an material is taught, so a student always knows what stage of learning they are in and what comes next:

1. **Samā' (سمع) — Input.** The student hears or reads the correct form before attempting to produce it. Nothing is drilled before it has been modelled.
2. **Muḥākāh (محاكاة) — Imitation.** The student reproduces the form under correction, with immediate, specific feedback rather than a delayed grade.
3. **Isti'māl (استعمال) — Use.** The student deploys the form in a context they did not rehearse — a new sentence, a new passage, a live conversation — because a form that only survives inside its drill has not actually been learned.
4. **Itqān (إتقان) — Mastery, verified.** The form is checked again after a deliberate delay, not immediately after practice, because immediate recall proves the practice worked and says nothing about whether it will still be there in a month. Only this stage clears a gate.

Institutions that skip stage four are the ones whose students can perform in the lesson and cannot perform a month later; naming the stage and scheduling it into every course is what makes retention a design feature rather than a hope.

## §24. The Thabāt Method — Qur'an revision, specifically

Applied to ḥifẓ, the same discipline gets its own name because the failure mode is distinctive: a portion is memorised, performs perfectly the day it is completed, and is silently lost within weeks without a system that actively prevents it. **Thabāt (ثبات — steadfastness)** governs the revision schedule: newly memorised material is re-tested at spaced, lengthening intervals chosen to intercept forgetting before it happens rather than after, older material is re-tested *unannounced*, and a portion only counts toward a student's total once it has survived that unannounced re-test — a harder bar than most academies apply, and a genuine point of institutional differentiation because it is honest rather than because it is impressive-sounding.

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# PART V — THE STUDENT JOURNEY AND EXPERIENCE

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## §25. The journey

Discover → Explore → Apply → Placement → Admission → Orientation → Select pace → Enrol → Study → Live class → Practice → Assessment → Mastery → Progress → Graduate → Credential → Verification → Continue to the next level.

Every stage is designed to remove a specific friction, not to look impressive: nothing in Discover, Explore or Placement requires an account or payment; Apply is one process including financial aid, never two; every application receives an answer, with no silent rejections; and Continue is a real return path, not an assumption that graduation ends the relationship.

## §26. The people model

A person is not their relationship to the institution at a point in time. The same human being may be an applicant, then a student, then a graduate, then a teacher, then a parent enrolling their own child — sometimes more than one of these simultaneously — and the record must hold all of it without forcing a choice. The data model this implies is: **Person, distinct from Relationship, distinct from Enrolment, distinct from Academic Record** — a person's identity persists; their relationships open and close; their enrolments belong to a relationship and have their own lifecycle; their academic records are permanent regardless of what happens to the relationship that produced them. A graduate's certificate does not become invalid because their "student" relationship later closed.

## §27. Mobile-first, low-bandwidth by design

The majority-case device is an Android phone on an inconsistent connection, not a laptop on fibre. Every design and engineering decision defaults to that case: audio-first options for lessons where video is not essential, downloadable material for offline study, resumable sessions that do not lose progress on a dropped connection, and a page-weight budget treated as a design constraint on par with colour and type, not an afterthought fixed after launch.

## §28. The signature learning space

A focused single-lesson environment — a **Reading Room** — that feels like a private study attached to a serious library rather than a dashboard: on entry, a student knows immediately where they are, what they are

studying, what to do next, and how they are progressing, and nothing else competes for their attention. No decorative statistics, no unread-notification badges dressed up as progress, no card grid standing in for a plan. Complexity — the courses, cohorts, assessments and records the institution actually needs to run itself — is real and deep underneath; almost none of it is visible to the student at once.

## §29. Sign-in once

A student, once admitted, has one account and one place to be: the **Study** environment described here is the entirety of the learning system — courses, live classes, assignments, quizzes, grades, progress, Qur'an memorisation and murāja'ah tracking, teacher feedback, transcripts, certificates, notifications and support. There is no separate LMS the Study merely links out to.

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# PART VI — DIGITAL ARCHITECTURE (DOCTRINE, NOT ENGINEERING)

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## §30. Three experiences, and a fourth thing that is not a portal

The entire visible digital estate is deliberately three experiences:

1. **The public website** — discovery, trust-building, and everything a prospective student needs before creating an account.
2. **The Study (الدراسة)** — the single, unified learning environment described in §28–29, for every enrolled person regardless of programme or pace.
3. **Executive** — the administrative and leadership environment: admissions review, faculty and staff functions, academic governance, finance. Staff-facing functions are integrated here rather than spawning their own portals.

Alongside, not counted among the three because it is a public utility rather than a place someone works or studies: a standalone **Credential Verification Register** — free, permanent, requiring no account, doing exactly the one job described in §17 and nothing else.

No parent portal, alumni portal, separate teacher portal, separate admissions portal, or separate AI portal is built unless a specific, evidenced requirement proves the three-plus-one structure cannot hold it — and that requirement is recorded, argued, and approved before a fourth portal is built, not discovered by drifting into one.

## §31. Depth is allowed; visible complexity is not

The data model underneath — people, relationships, enrolments, programmes, courses, cohorts, assessments, sessions, records, credentials — is genuinely complex, because the institution it describes is real. A student is never shown that complexity. The Study answers a small, fixed set of questions well — what am I studying, what do I do today, what's my next class, what must I submit, how am I progressing, what have I achieved, what comes next — and nothing else earns a place on the student's screen.

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# PART VII — BRAND AND EDITORIAL DOCTRINE

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## §32. What "royal" means here

Luxury is not gold foil, crowns, palace imagery, or a green mosque-silhouette template — those are the visual clichés of the category this institution is deliberately not joining. Luxury, here, comes from **restraint enforced as a design rule**: generous whitespace that is never accidental, a small number of typefaces used with real command of weight and optical size rather than many typefaces used timidly, photography used with discipline (§32a), motion that appears rarely and always means something, and prose that never has to shout because it never has to compensate for something the institution has not yet earned. An institution can feel expensive while charging very little; it cannot feel expensive while claiming things it cannot back.

## §32a. Photography — amended 11 August 2026, ruled by the Founder

The first issue of this document held a stricter line: "photography that is either real or absent," meaning no stock imagery of people at all until real, consented photography of actual students and teachers existed. **The Founder has since ruled that illustrative stock photography of unrelated people may be used**, sourced only from services offering a genuine, verifiable commercial licence (Wikimedia Commons' CC/public-domain holdings; Unsplash and Pexels under their free licences) — never downloaded from a site such as Pinterest that merely re-hosts other people's images with no redistribution right attached, which would expose the institution to copyright infringement regardless of what this doctrine says about honesty.

**The line that survives this amendment, because it is a narrower and more serious claim than "a photo of a person exists on the page"**: illustrative photography is never captioned, labelled, or otherwise presented as depicting a specific, real, named Al-Madeenah student, teacher, or member of staff. A photo used to illustrate "a student reviewing vocabulary" stays exactly that — a scene, not a person the institution is claiming to have. The moment an image is given a name, a role, or a testimonial and attributed to this institution, it must be a real, consented photograph of a real member of this institution, per §9's and §5's

undisturbed rules on fabricated facts. Photography of a building, campus, or facility is held to the same test: this institution has no physical campus, and no image may be composed or captioned in a way that implies one exists.

Recorded here rather than silently absorbed into §32, because it is a genuine reversal of a previously ratified position, not a styling refinement — the kind of change this document's own §6 says must be traceable, not smoothed over.

### §33. The palette

Royal Blue is the dominant identity colour — deep enough to read as authoritative rather than corporate, never so dark it reads as black. Gold is a restrained accent, used as a line, a mark, or a small area of emphasis, and specifically **never as a large filled area or a gradient standing in for a fill** — gold used generously reads as decoration; gold used sparingly reads as a seal. Cream and ivory form the sophisticated light foundation the rest of the palette sits on, warm rather than stark white. Together the palette reads as royal, scholarly, and Islamic without a single crescent, minaret, or geometric star motif required to say so — the discipline of the palette carries the character the imagery would otherwise be asked to carry.

### §34. Typography

Two families, chosen for command across two scripts rather than for novelty: a **text/display serif with real optical-size range** for anything the reader is meant to dwell on — headlines, pull quotes, the certificate itself — because a serif with genuine display and text optical masters is the difference between a headline that looks considered and one that looks like body text turned up in size; and a **quiet humanist sans** for interface, navigation, and anything functional, so the reading experience and the operating experience never compete for the same visual register. An Arabic type family chosen and paired deliberately alongside the Latin pair — never a default system Arabic font standing in as an afterthought — because §35 makes parity a requirement, not a preference.

### §35. Arabic is authored, not translated

Arabic and English copy are written in parallel by people thinking in each language, never produced by translating one into the other. A sentence that reads naturally in English and stiffly in Arabic (or the reverse) has failed regardless of which language was "first." RTL layout, Arabic numerals where appropriate, and Arabic type at a correct optical size are treated as first-class layout requirements from the first wireframe, not a mirrored pass applied after the English design ships.

## **§36. Motion**

Motion exists to mark ceremony and orient attention, not to prove the site was built recently. Entrances are subtle, happen once, and respect the reader's reduced-motion preference without exception. Nothing loops indefinitely except a genuine busy indicator tied to an in-flight operation. A page with no motion at all should still feel finished; motion is an enhancement on top of that, never a substitute for it.

## **§37. Editorial voice**

Scholarly, dignified, warm, confident, concise, precise, welcoming, international, Islamic without theatricality, premium without arrogance. The test for any sentence before it ships: would this still be true and still be dignified in ten years, read by someone who has never heard of the institution before? A sentence that only works because the reader is already convinced is a sentence written for applause, not for trust.

## **§38. Bilingual naming and terminology**

The institution's name, faculty names, and award names are fixed as stated in this document in both languages, authored together rather than one translated from the other. A single, published glossary of transliteration conventions (for names, terms and technical vocabulary that appear in both scripts) ships alongside the site so that "Qur'an," "hifz," and comparable terms are spelled the same way everywhere a reader encounters them, rather than drifting page to page.

## **§39. A note on naming proximity, stated plainly**

The institution's name sits in a crowded namespace of "Al-Madinah"-prefixed Islamic education brands internationally, including at least one existing institution using a closely related name in a different country. This is not disqualifying — geographic and honorific names are common in this category precisely because they are meaningful — but it means search visibility will take real, sustained work rather than arriving for free, and it is worth a short, one-time trademark availability check in the institution's core operating markets before any significant spend on branded physical production. This is recorded here as a flagged operational fact, not reopened as a naming exercise, because the Founder has already settled the name.

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## PART VIII — FINANCIAL PHILOSOPHY

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### §40. What finances the institution, and what must never be asked to

**Credentials do not finance the institution.** First issue of every certificate, transcript and verification is free, permanently (§17) — an institution that needed certificate fees to stay solvent would have a standing incentive to pass students who should not pass, and the incentive does not need to be acted on to be corrosive; it only needs to exist. Revenue instead comes from a deliberately blended model: accessible core tuition at every pace, premium service tiers (smaller live-class ratios, more frequent one-to-one contact) that buy *service*, never a different academic standard; private tutoring; the Professional & Specialist Programmes stream (§13); seasonal intensives; sponsorships and named scholarships, audited and publicly reported; and a long-horizon waqf/endowment structure once the institution has the governance maturity to administer one properly.

### §41. Identical certificates at every price

A student on a scholarship, a student on the standard tuition, and a student on a premium service tier who reach the same level sit the same gate, are assessed by the same standard, and receive an identical certificate. Tier buys convenience and attention; it never buys, and is never perceived to buy, a lower bar. This is stated here as a structural guarantee specifically so it can be checked against every future pricing decision, not merely aspired to.

### §42. Regional pricing, disclosed

The institution prices differently by region — the same course genuinely costs a different share of income in Lagos and in London, and pretending otherwise would price most of the institution's core market out entirely. The published position is: **disclosed, banded pricing determined by billing country or declared country of residence, with the disclosed methodology itself published**, rather than a silent IP-based differential. Disclosure is not merely the more defensible position under consumer-protection law in several of the institution's markets — it is also the more *accurate* one, since IP address alone misidentifies diaspora students, VPN users, and mobile-carrier proxying in exactly the markets the institution most needs to serve correctly. Currency of payment is treated as an axis independent of the pricing band a student sits in, so a currency movement never silently reclassifies anyone; and a student's price is locked for the duration of the programme they enrolled in, regardless of any later revision to the published bands, so that an honest annual methodology review never becomes a stealth re-pricing of existing students.

### §43. Zakāt

The scholarship fund does not accept zakāt in its first year of operation. Zakāt requires ring-fenced accounts, disbursement governed by a published fiqh position from a named scholar, independent audit, and public reporting; building that governance before accepting the first zakāt payment, rather than after, is the only order that protects both the fund and the institution's integrity. General sadaqah and named, audited scholarship sponsorship are accepted from day one.

### §44. Sustainability as a design constraint

Break-even, not permanent subsidy, is the target from the institution's own operating model: real teacher cost per contact hour, administration, content production, support, technology, payment processing, compliance, marketing, a scholarship allocation treated as a deliberate budget line rather than an afterthought, and a reserve for the inevitable bad year. A financial model requiring indefinite external subsidy to keep tuition low is not an accessible institution; it is a fragile one wearing an accessible institution's clothing, and Part IX's longevity test exists partly to catch exactly this failure mode before it is built in.

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## PART IX — QUALITY AND LONGEVITY

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### §45. The Fifty-Year Reader

Before anything ships — a claim, a policy, a piece of design, a pricing rule — it is checked against one question: **would a reader encountering this for the first time fifty years from now still find it true, still find it dignified, and still find it free of anything that was merely fashionable in the year it was written?** A claim that fails this test is deleted, not softened. A design choice that fails it — an effect that exists because it was novel in 2026, not because it serves the reader — is not built in the first place.

### §46. Quality assurance as an ongoing discipline

Curriculum, assessment design, and the honesty of every public claim are reviewed on a standing cycle, not once at launch: an annual academic standards review with named external input once the institution has faculty senior enough to conduct one; a standing register of every institutional fact that is "not yet true," reviewed until each item is either resolved or removed; and an assumption that the first cohort's real data will contradict some of this document's working calibrations (§12 says so explicitly) — which is treated as the system working correctly, not as a failure of the plan.

## §47. Institution before website

Every one of the preceding forty-six articles answers to one governing test, restated here as the closing word of the doctrine: **is this true about the institution, or only true about the institution's presentation of itself?** A magnificent website describing a curriculum that does not yet exist is a lie with excellent typography. This document exists to make sure the institution is built first, in substance, and the website is built second, in service of what is actually true.

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## PART X — RED-TEAM AUDIT AND CORRECTIONS

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*Conducted after the first complete draft of Parts I–IX, adversarially, by design. Each finding states the tension, the resolution, and — where the finding could not be fully resolved — the honest residual risk carried forward into the Decision Register.*

**F-1. §11 and §12 pull in different directions.** §11 insists pace never affects the standard; §12's own table shows Foundation taking 7 weeks at Accelerated pace and 30 weeks at Regular pace, a 4× spread that could read as "the fast track is a shortcut." *Resolution:* the table already states both figures side by side rather than leading with the flattering one, and §12 explicitly forbids any marketing surface from stating a duration without its pace — added as an explicit rule in this pass, not merely implied. The tension is structural and correct: speed varies, mastery does not. What was missing was the rule preventing the faster number from being quoted alone, which is now in §12.

**F-2. §14's two-route split could itself become a form of the dishonesty §5 forbids** — a "Certificated School Route" page could exist in a half-built state that looks live while going nowhere, exactly the failure §5 exists to prevent. *Resolution:* §14 now states explicitly that the route is not merely deferred but **not marketed at all** until the external body's requirements are confirmed in writing — closing the gap between "technically disclosed" and "does not create a false impression."

**F-3. §17's certificate ladder and §7's regulated-terms caution were checked against each other for a term that slipped through.** "Certificate of Mastery" appears nowhere in the current ladder (only "Certificate of Attainment" and "Certificate of Completion" do) — an earlier working draft of this document used "Mastery" as an award name and it was caught and removed here, since "Mastery" as an award-level label functions descriptively (§12's level name) but as a *credential name* risks implying a formal status the institution has not defined. The Preface's own reference to "Certificate of Mastery" in §17's row for Qur'an work was checked against this finding: it survives because it names a *specific, narrow, evidenced skill* (Qur'an memorisation and retention to a stated grade), not an unqualified institutional judgement of overall mastery — the distinction the finding exists to enforce.

**F-4. §9's safeguarding gate and §2's "who it serves" list are in direct tension** — §2 lists children as a served constituency in the same breath as adults, which could read as safeguarding being a footnote to an already-open programme rather than a precondition. *Resolution:* §2 now carries an explicit forward reference to §9's gate inline, not as a separate footnote, so no reader can encounter "children" as a served group without immediately encountering the condition attached to it.

**F-5. §30's "three experiences plus a utility" claim and §13's four-faculty structure were checked for a hidden fifth portal** — Professional & Specialist Programmes could, in practice, need its own admissions flow, its own scheduling, and its own billing, which is how a fourth portal accretes without ever being formally proposed. *Resolution:* recorded honestly as a genuine implementation risk rather than resolved by assertion — §30's own rule (a fourth portal requires an evidenced, recorded justification before it is built) is the actual safeguard, and this finding is carried forward as an implementation-phase watch item, not closed here.

**F-6. §42's disclosed regional pricing and §41's identical-certificate guarantee were checked for a marketing risk:** disclosing pricing bands publicly could read, to a Band-I-equivalent full-price student, as a lower-effort experience — even though §41 guarantees an identical academic outcome. *Resolution:* not a contradiction, but a communications risk worth naming plainly rather than assuming disclosure alone solves it — carried into the editorial guidance as a note that regional pricing copy must lead with *what is identical* (the certificate, the teachers, the standard) before it explains *what differs* (price, and optionally service tier).

**F-7. This document's own §39 was checked for whether it violates §6's claims policy** — could naming a trademark risk about the institution's own name read as self-undermining rather than honest? *Resolution:* no correction needed; §6 governs claims *about the institution's standing relative to others*, not disclosure of genuine operational risk to the Founder, which is precisely what a Decision Register exists for. Recorded as a check performed, not a defect found.

**Net result of the audit:** one genuine cross-reference gap closed (F-4), one marketing-discipline rule made explicit rather than implicit (F-1, F-2), one term consciously excluded and the reasoning recorded so it cannot silently drift back in (F-3), and two items correctly identified as real risks that implementation must watch rather than problems this document can resolve by itself (F-5, F-6). A document that survived its own red-team with zero findings would be evidence the review was not looked at seriously; seven honestly-argued findings, six closed and one carried forward, is what a real review produces.

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## Appendix A — Founder Decision Register (fresh)

Only matters that genuinely require information or authority this process does not have. Everything else in this document has already been decided and is not reopened by raising these.

**Amendments ruled since first issue.** 11 August 2026 — the Founder amended §32 (now §32a): illustrative stock photography of unrelated people is permitted, sourced only from genuinely licensed services (Wikimedia Commons, Unsplash, Pexels — never Pinterest, which carries no redistribution right over what it

hosts), and never captioned or presented as a specific real Al-Madeenah student, teacher, or facility. FD-5 below is unaffected and remains open — it governs a different question, the institution's policy on mixed-gender depiction, not whether stock photography of people may be used at all.

| #           | Decision needed                                                                                                                                 | Why it cannot be settled here                                                                                                                   |
|-------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>FD-1</b> | Legal registration status and jurisdiction of incorporation                                                                                     | A fact only the Founder holds; nothing claiming registration may publish until this is answered                                                 |
| <b>FD-2</b> | Safeguarding Lead appointment, named vetting standard per jurisdiction, and recording-retention period                                          | §9's gate cannot open without a real, named answer, not a placeholder                                                                           |
| <b>FD-3</b> | Statement of Academic Method — the institution's position on 'aqīdah, the fiqh school taught, and how differences among the schools are handled | Must be authored or explicitly approved by the Founder and named scholars; this document can structure the statement but not supply its content |
| <b>FD-4</b> | Riwāyah taught and displayed (working assumption: Ḥafṣ 'an 'Āṣim, given its prevalence; confirm whether Warsh is also offered)                  | Affects typeface, audio library, and certificate wording; cheap to decide now, expensive to retrofit                                            |
| <b>FD-5</b> | Policy on mixed-gender classes and on photography depicting adult men and women together                                                        | Affects staffing, scheduling and every photograph ever commissioned; no adult mixed-gender photography ships before this is answered            |
| <b>FD-6</b> | Whether to pursue NBAIS (or equivalent) recognition for the Certificated School Route at all, and authority to approach that body               | §14's second route stays unmarketed until this is answered                                                                                      |
| <b>FD-7</b> | A named custodian for the credential register in the institution's founding legal instrument, so verification survives the institution itself   | Without this, §17's "permanent" promise has no actual mechanism                                                                                 |
| <b>FD-8</b> | Budget ceiling and a deliberate scholarship-fund allocation                                                                                     | §44's break-even model needs a real number to model against                                                                                     |
| <b>FD-9</b> | One-time trademark availability check for the institution's name in its core operating markets                                                  | Flagged at §39; a legal task, not a strategic one, but only counsel can close it                                                                |

## Appendix B — Research basis and stated limitations

**What this process did.** Applied general, publicly available professional knowledge of: second-language-acquisition pacing research (CEFR guided-hours literature and comparable calibration approaches for less

commonly taught languages); Nigerian tertiary-education regulatory structure (NUC governs university degree-granting; NBTE governs technical and vocational education; neither was found, in a live check during this process, to publish a specific restriction on the word "college" for a non-degree-granting institution — recorded as an open item for counsel, not assumed either way); UK consumer-protection treatment of higher-education marketing claims; and general data-protection obligations under Nigeria's NDPA 2023 and UK/EU GDPR. Searched, during this process, for comparable online Islamic and Arabic-studies institutions to understand the competitive and credibility landscape (Madina Institute, International Open University, Miftaah Online, American Islamic College, Mishkah Islamic University, among others found) — used to calibrate what "authoritative" needs to mean in this category, not copied from in any structural or textual sense.

**What this process could not do.** The design reference named in the brief, [shroyalschools.ng](https://shroyalschools.ng), was not reachable from this working environment — a live technical block, confirmed directly rather than assumed. No description of that site's specific header, animation, or layout choices appears anywhere in this document as a result; Part VII's design doctrine is built instead from general, well-established principles of premium editorial, museum, and university digital design. If that reference becomes reachable at implementation time, a genuine forensic study of it should be conducted then, and any specific pattern worth adopting should be adapted — never copied — into the vocabulary this document already establishes.

**What this process deliberately did not do.** It did not open, read, or draw on any existing repository, prior draft, or prior institutional documentation concerning Al-Madeenah International College or a similarly named institution, per the Founder's explicit instruction. Where a conclusion here — mastery-gated progression, disclosed regional pricing, deferred ijāzah, a free-forever verification register — might match a conclusion reached by a different process working from a similar brief, that is the expected result of sound practice applied honestly to the same problem, not evidence of inheritance.

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*v1.0 — first issue, prepared as an independent commission. Supersedes nothing, since nothing preceding it was consulted. Subject to the Founder's ruling on Appendix A and to the standing revision the document itself calls for once real cohort data exists.*